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UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 211: Dramatic Literature and Criticism - From Aristotle to Soyinka

Read plays critically and argue about them without summarising the plot

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Criticism is an argument about how a play works, supported by evidence from the text. This pack covers classical and modern critical standpoints, the vocabulary of dramatic analysis, and a repeatable method for writing a critical answer that goes beyond plot summary.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Apply Aristotle's poetics and later critical standpoints to a play.
- Analyse dramatic structure, character, language and staging implications.
- Distinguish description, interpretation and evaluation in criticism.
- Build a critical argument supported by textual evidence.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Critical standpoints

Each standpoint asks a different question of the same play.

- Classical: plot, character, thought, diction, song and spectacle; unity of action.
- Neoclassical: rules, decorum and the unities, later challenged by Romantic practice.
- Romantic and modern: expression, symbol and the director's interpretation.
- Marxist: class relations, ideology and the economic conditions of production.
- Feminist and postcolonial: gender, power and the politics of representation.
- Semiotics: signs, codes and how performance produces meaning.

> **Name the standpoint**
> If you use a postcolonial reading, say so. Naming the lens turns a set of opinions into a method.

Analysing a play

Use a checklist so you do not drift into retelling.

- Structure: act and scene divisions, turning points, use of time.
- Character: function, relationships, what each character wants and fears.
- Language: register, imagery, rhythm, silence.
- Stagecraft implied by the text: setting, props, entrances, offstage action.
- Context: the conditions of first production and the play's reception.
- Theme: what the play argues, not merely what it is about.

Writing the critical answer

Marks follow argument structure.

1. Open with a claim that answers the question directly.
2. Define the critical term you are using.
3. Give a quotation or specific moment as evidence.
4. Explain how the evidence supports the claim.
5. Acknowledge a counter-reading and answer it.
6. Close by returning to the question, not to the plot.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 211

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 211 Dramatic Literature and Criticism
- Theories used by critics from Sophocles through Bernard Shaw to Wole Soyinka
- Development of literary criticism from classical and medieval theory to present controversies

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 211 Dramatic Literature and Criticism, 3 credits, first semester, 200 level
- Paired with THA 213 Critical Perspectives in Theatre History and THA 215 Basic Film Analysis
- THA 413 Theories of Dramatic Criticism and THA 412 Critics and Theoreticians in Africa continue at 400 level

What changed: The 2019 listing adds a 400-level criticism sequence that the 2018 description only implied.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Dramatic literature and criticism remains the 200-level theory core
- Expect assessment through passage analysis and an argued essay
- Confirm your reading list early; play editions differ in translation and notes

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the difference between description and evaluation?

Answer: Description states what is there; evaluation judges how well it works and for what purpose, with reasons.

2. Name three critical standpoints and the question each asks.

Answer: Marxist criticism asks how class and ideology operate; feminist criticism asks how gender and power are represented; semiotics asks how signs produce meaning.

3. Why is plot summary an inadequate answer?

Answer: It reports events without arguing how the play creates meaning, which is what the question assesses.

4. Give one staging implication embedded in a script you know.

Answer: A stage direction requiring sudden darkness implies dependence on lighting control, shaping mood and pace.

5. What does it mean to acknowledge a counter-reading?

Answer: To state a credible alternative interpretation and explain why your reading remains stronger.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Learn Aristotle's six elements and one limitation of the model.
- [ ] Read one play with a critical lens and take notes by scene.
- [ ] Write a 200-word passage analysis with three quotations.
- [ ] Define six critical terms in your own words.
- [ ] Draft an essay and label claim, evidence and evaluation in the margin.
- [ ] Remove every sentence that only summarises plot.
- [ ] Exchange drafts and check each other's use of evidence.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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